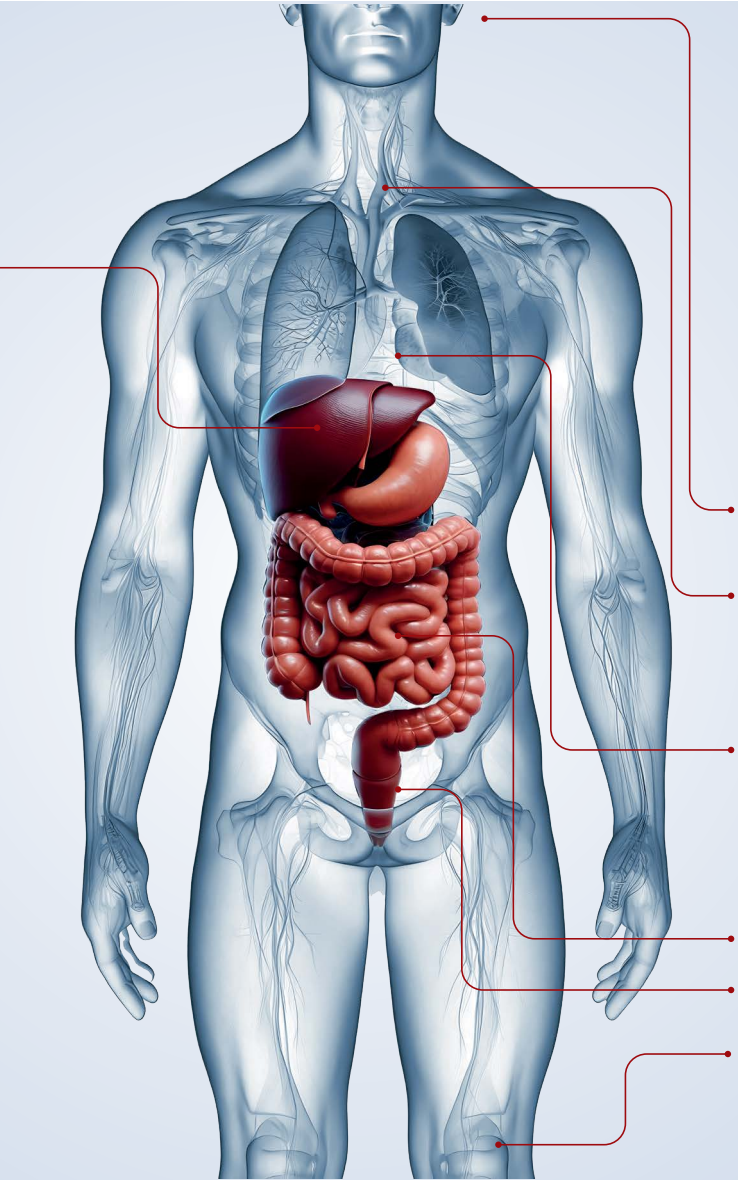


WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOUR LIVER IS UNHEALTHY

The first impact is directly on your body's insulin sensitivity. NAFLD increases by at least twofold the risk of having type 2 diabetes and cardiovascular disease. It has also been linked to:

- Loss of brain function
- Obstructive sleep apnea
- Lowered immunity
- Gastroesophageal reflux disease which causes heart burn, acid reflux and regurgitation
- Poor gut health
- Cancer
- Osteoporosis

HOW YOU CAN SAFEGUARD YOUR LIVER

- The food you eat plays a huge role. For good liver health, it is important to include omega 3 fatty acids, antioxidants, Vitamin E. The American Liver Association recommends good amount of fibre, monosaturated fats and hydration. New research suggests a role for dairy fats
- Make sure your weight is within the normal BMI range
- Ensure your blood sugar, blood pressure and blood cholesterol are in the safe range
- Exercise regularly
- Practise safe sex to reduce risk of hepatits B and C
- Follow directions when on medications
- Avoid alcohol

tory processes act in a tightly controlled fashion. Failure to clear such dangerous stimuli and resolve inflammation leads to chronic pathological inflammation and disrupted tissue homeostasis, which can progress to fibrosis, cirrhosis and liver failure," says Dr Chandra.

Fatty liver usually starts off as a simple, harmless stage-designated steatosis. It is revealed in other imaging tests, like an abdomen scan. The second stage is non-alcoholic steatohepatitis (NASH) when the liver starts to get inflamed, in response to overaccumulation of fat cells inside or around it. "In NAFLD, fat accumulates inside the hepatocytes, or the liver cells. This fat causes functional deficits by physically displacing cellular components. Additionally, it acts as an irritant, triggering the body's immune response, which slowly damages the cells, eventually leading to cell death," explains Dr Cherian. This gradual process of liver cells getting destroyed is what we know as fibrosis. Thin bands of scar tissues start to build up, reducing blood flow through the liver and thus its access to oxygen and nutrients needed for its wellbeing. Until this stage, the damage is still reversible. Beyond this, though, it can proceed to cirrhosis, a severe, permanent scarring in your liver. In its advanced stages, your liver no longer has enough healthy cells left to work with and can no longer regenerate. Eventually, this can lead to liver failure, the point when the organ is unable to function to meet your body's needs. The only chance of survival at this stage is a liver transplant.

Unfortunately, most people with Stage 1 or 2 NAFLD treat it lightly as the damage is reversible. But, as Dr Sarin says, "Too much fat in your liver, whether early or advanced stage, reversible or not, is dangerous for your health in multiple ways." The first impact is directly on your body's insulin sensitivity. NAFLD increases by at least twofold the risk of having type 2 diabetes and cardiovascular disease, according to a 2020 study in the journal *Current Opinion in Lipidology*. In fact, so high is the link between fatty liver and metabolic diseases that